

The renewed sparring between the Congress and the Left could jeopardise projects worth crores cleared by the Centre



party's national executive committee, which met at its state President Panakkad Shihab Thangal's residence in Malappuram, decided to express its "concerns" over the nuclear pact but vote in support of the Government in the confidence motion.

The IUML also unofficially resolved to withdraw its lone member of Parliament, Union Minister of State for External Affairs E. Ahamed, from the Union Cabinet as a gesture of sacrifice. It was the 60-year-old party's first-ever berth in the Union Cabinet. But it wasn't long before Ahamed sung to a different tune as he reached Delhi and announced that he would not resign from the Cabinet. It's not difficult to guess that the instructions came from the Congress leadership that does not want the nuclear deal to be perceived as anti-Muslim. "It has not yet been decided that I will resign. The IUML-Congress ties have lasted for four decades and have had the blessings of Nehru and Indira. A problem for the UPA would be perceived as an advantage for the fascist BJP, and the IUML won't let that happen," he said.

Ahamed was also equally vocal about the several pro-minority steps

National Development Front (NDF) that have launched a campaign against the pact and the IUML's supposed "sellout" to the US. But the party's agonies are not just restricted to these outfits. The CPI(M) that has already made an impression in the community through its anti-US rhetoric is likely to gain further if the IUML chooses to take a moderate stand on the issue. Here, the IUML ought to remember how its strong ties with the Congress during the demolition of Babri Masjid in 1992 had eroded its once undisputed votebank among the state's 79 lakh Muslims (24.7 per cent of the population).

Cut to present, the party's unofficial decision to withdraw Ahamed has now led to an internal chaos. For the pro-Ahamed faction, this appears to be an opportunistic ploy by its rivals (led by the party's General Secretary P.K. Kunhalikutty) to deprive their leader of ministership. As a result, many voices supporting Ahamed can be heard. While K.M. Shaji, general secretary of the Muslim Youth League, says there is no need for Ahamed to quit because "the nuclear pact is not against Muslims and is good for India", former PWD minister and

The Indian Union Muslim League is caught in a bind. Neither it wants to snap ties with the Congress nor can it afford to antagonise its core votebank.

that the UPA Government had taken in the past four years. "It was this Government that awarded scholarships to 25 lakh minority students, allowed Palestine to set up diplomatic offices in Delhi, increased Haj pilgrim quota and tabled Sachar Committee report. No other government has done so much for the minorities."

However, Ahamed's sudden volte-face has left many red-faced in the IUML. Even though the party doesn't want to antagonise the Congress, it realises that without a show of sacrifice, its image in the community is in the danger of taking a beating. The IUML's predicament has also proved beneficial for other Muslim outfits like the People's Democratic Party (PDP), Kerala Muslim Jamaat Muslim Council and

Ahamed loyalist M.K. Muneer argues, "Why have they failed to make their comrade Somnath Chatterjee resign from speakership?" The State Congress has also welcomed Ahamed's decision. Party state President Ramesh Chennithala says, "L.K. Advani is more dangerous than George Bush." But Kunhalikutty insists that Ahamed will have to quit the Cabinet if Thangal desired so because "any deal with the US would be against the interests of Muslims all over the world".

For the state which was for long a laggard as far as growth was concerned, the last four years were a turnaround. But with the political foes-turned-friends turning foes again, Kerala may slip back to the bad old days of deprivation and lack of growth. ■